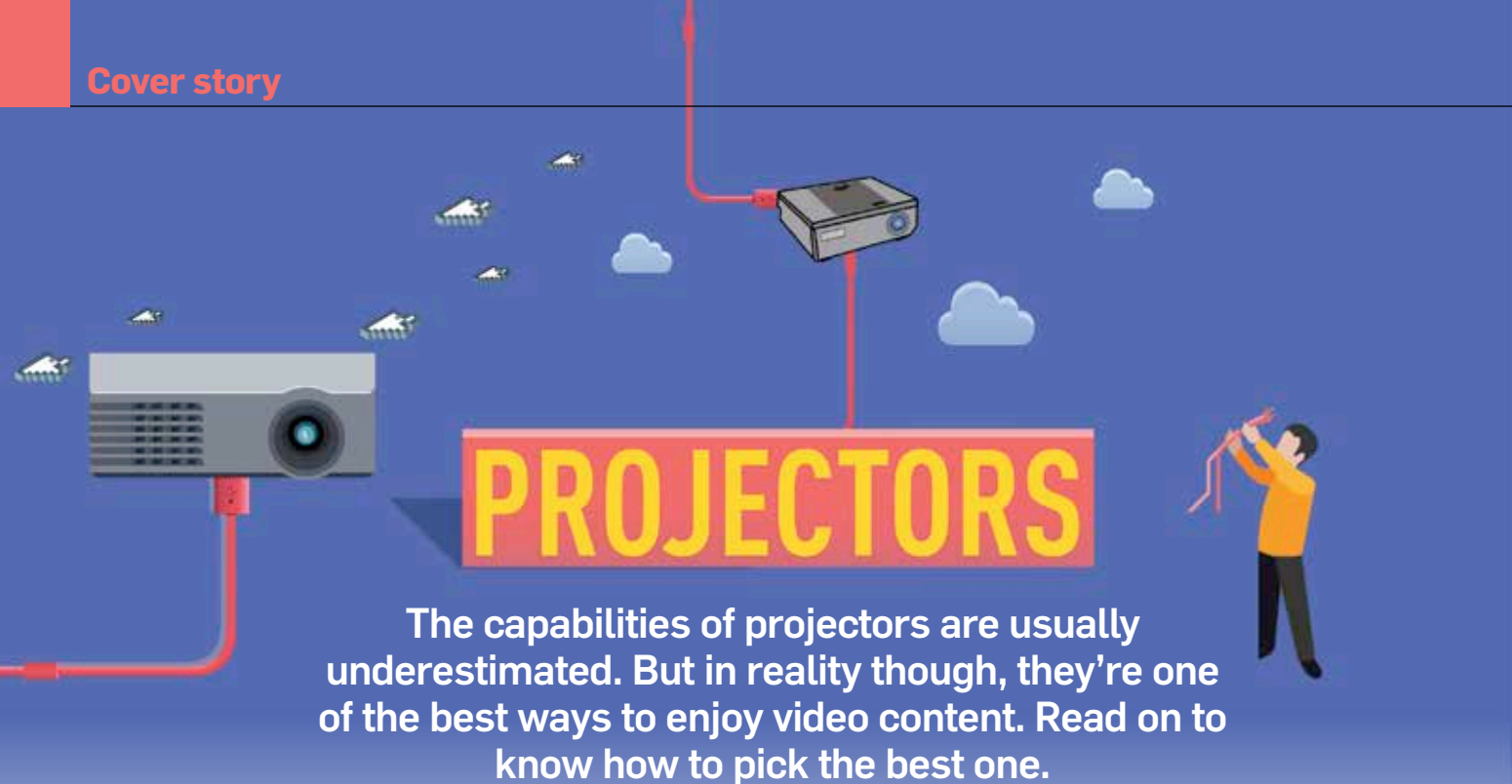




The capabilities of projectors are usually underestimated. But in reality though, they're one of the best ways to enjoy video content. Read on to know how to pick the best one.

By **Jayesh Shinde**

We seldom think of projectors as the centrepiece of our home entertainment system, always desiring to invest in a big screen HDTV instead. Perhaps the deep-seated notion that projectors are expensive and mostly for commercial use is an added deterrent. It's only something you witness inside a cinema hall on a weekend, most people believe it's out of their reach.

Just drive that notion out of your head. Granted that having a projector setup in a household isn't the same as installing a



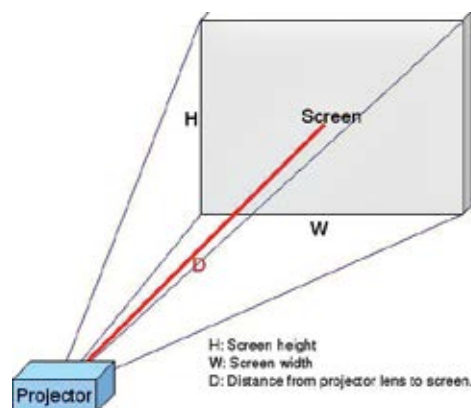
large screen high-definition LCD TV, there are some clear advantages the former enjoys over the latter. With a projector, any room can be a movie room – be it the living room or guest room, wall or ceiling – and the resulting image it throws can be bigger, better and larger than your HDTV. Most HDTVs measuring over 40 inches are priced between ₹50,000 to ₹1,00,000

– so are most good home entertainment projectors. But when you're considering to purchase a home entertainment projector, pay attention to the following things:

1 Brightness and Contrast: While buying a projector, brightness of picture is a top priority. We know that you may not be able to test this out yourself, but nothing stops you from visiting electronic stores and trying out projectors. In our experience, we've found 3LCD projectors to be slightly better and brighter than conventional DLP ones. But the margin is very fine. Thumb rule is to buy a brighter projector if you aren't guaranteed a fully dark, theatre-like room at home for your movie-watching sessions.

While you should always consider buying a projector with a high native contrast ratio, most projectors tout dynamic contrast ratios (taking into account technologies and features that add on to the native contrast ratio) which are very difficult to ascertain by you. It happens in real-time where the projector adjusts the light output at any given frame of image. But always remember that projectors with a high dynamic contrast ratio may not perform as well as a projector with a high native contrast ratio.

2 Throw Distance: This matters a lot in urban homes that have space constraints. Consider buying a short throw or ultra short throw projector if you don't have large rooms, or don't want the distance between the projector and the screen to be more than a metre, so it doesn't block space unnecessarily. Ultra short throw projectors are capable of sitting a few inches from a wall or screen and project between a 40 to 60-inch image without a hitch, from what we've seen.



3 Resolution: We can't stress enough on this aspect. If you are considering purchasing a home entertainment projector – for watching Blu-ray or 1080p